power politics. It is politics, after all, that creates nations, borders, leaders, laws, and ideologies. Politics in turn is shaped by power, whether military, economic, cultural, or ideological. In contrast to national politics, international politics is defined by anarchy: the absence of an overarching central authority that can enforce recognized laws such as a world government or global police force. The international stage is thus a naturally competitive place, whether due to a human urge to dominate or due to persistent mistrust.

Many other 'realist' lessons find ready examples from Indian history. [87] The constant competition and regular warfare among Indian states are indicative of the security dilemma, whereby states seeking security for themselves contribute to the insecurity of others. Threat perceptions constantly changed because of geography, resources, ideology, and technology, reflected in India's experiences with Greek, Huna, Arab, Afghan, Turkic, Mongol, and Persian invaders from the north-west. Throughout this history, rapid changes caused leaders to misperceive intentions and miscalculate. This was sometimes the result of technological breakthroughs, changes in political leadership, or organizational developments; perhaps the most dramatic of these transformations involved the arrival of European colonial powers. In early modern India, various actors—Sikhs, Marathas, Afghans, Nepalis, British, French, Portuguese, and Ottomans—understood the importance and value of instrumental coalitions and alliances. India today can draw lessons from these and other experiences. Ultimately, modern India will have to act decisively to protect its national interests and should thus remain conscious of the inherently competitive nature of international politics, the sources of threat at any given point in time, the need to enhance its comprehensive national power, and the necessity at times to enter partnerships or coalitions to preserve a stable balance of power.

A second set of lessons involves the constancy of commerce. Trade is a consistent characteristic of India's interactions with the world throughout history, often playing a major role in eliciting interest from others, or otherwise shaping India's interactions with the outside world. Even if India